

# Interpreting the Results of Residue Analysis

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The greatest challenge in residue analysis is taking the mass spectra or infrared spectra produced by these analytical methods and interpreting an original foodstuff from them. Keep in mind the challenges: Compounds degrade over time, some more than others, resulting in the likelihood that data are incomplete. Multiple foods could have been cooked in the same pot over time, resulting in the mixture of different food traces together. Pulling apart these different lines of evidence is a challenge and results in a list of items used in the pot, rather than a reconstruction of a recipe or meal specifically. But even this incomplete picture provides a valuable and unique lens for food and cooking that complements the results of zooarchaeological and paleoethnobotanical analyses. Analyses of storage jars are simpler: Since such jars may only have been used a single time and contained a single substance, there is less chance for confusion, resulting in a better chance of reconstructing their original contents.